

SCALING THE HEIGHTS

Over 2 millennia ago, Aristotle said, "What is the essence of life? To serve others and to do good." It is a rather simple thought, yet holds true even today.

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The Institute of Hepatobiliary and Liver Transplant at BLK-MAX Super Speciality Hospital, New Delhi, is a center where the patient comes first. It functions efficiently under the skilled leadership of Dr. Abhideep Chaudhary, Senior Director & HOD, supported by his dedicated and proficient team. He has performed more than 2000 liver transplants and HPB surgeries.

In a heart-to-heart talk, Dr. Chaudhary opens up about his passion for relieving the burden of liver diseases and promoting cadaveric donations in India, strengthening people's trust, and advancing liver care in India, particularly with the introduction of robotic liver surgery, during a chat with India Today.

What began your journey in the field of liver transplantation?

For as long as I can remember, medicine has been my passion. Multiple influences during my childhood, most importantly, my father, a dedicated mathematician who strived for the best, led me to my path. When my older cousin underwent a kidney transplant, with the donor being his father, I was deeply moved. That kindled my passion to work in this field, and I never looked back. I became driven to work and to keep learning from my mentors to provide the optimum care to every patient. During my senior residency at AIIMS, I was fortunate to secure a transplant surgery fellowship position at the prestigious Thomas E. Starzl Transplantation Institute, known as the Mecca for transplant surgeons.

Could you tell us about your experience at the Thomas E. Starzl Institute?

During my time at the institute, I had the privilege of meeting the pioneer of liver transplant, Dr Thomas Starzl, a legendary surgeon who provided me with real life lessons. While sharing his wisdom about dealing with transplant patients and their loved ones, he said, "It is not just about transplantation, you are transplanting the family, so you have to be careful by taking care of every single emotion that they go through. It is not just the surgery but the emotional component, the recovery time, the family, apprehensions of the future that they go through, all that should be taken into account when you are taking care of them." His priceless advice, "Whatever you do, don't ever take away their hope" has been a guiding light for many transplant surgeons, including myself.

Who are the people that have had a large impact in your life?

I always say that the fabric of my life has been woven by my parents, my spouse, my mentors, my children, and my patients. They have shaped me into the person that I am today, and I continue to strive to be.

India has an alarming burden of liver diseases. What is the cause for this?

As per WHO estimates, approximately every 5th adult in India suffers from some kind of liver disease, viral hepatitis, fatty liver, and alcohol related liver disease being the most common. Almost 20 per cent of the world's liver related deaths happen in India.

A drastic and persistent rise in the incidence of fatty liver disease presents a worrisome statistic. Causes of fatty liver include wrong eating habits, sedentary lifestyle, obesity, and metabolic syndromes like diabetes, thyroid, hypertension, and dyslipidaemia. nN

Where does our country stand with regard to cadaveric donations?

India's large population of 1.4 billion should be our strength. Every year, around 80,000 people in India require liver transplants. However, the process of finding a viable donor is prolonged, in search for a close relative to become a donor. There is a large number of brain deaths every year in our country, who can donate organs including liver, kidneys, pancreas, heart, lungs, the list goes on. If we can convert them to be potential donors with the consent of the family and with proper awareness and management of those donors, it would save many lives which otherwise perish in their wait for a donor.

What are the recent advancements made by BLK-MAX Hospital in liver transplantation?

BLK-MAX Hospital has evolved into a high-functioning liver transplant center, having ventured into robotic donor surgery, a new horizon in live donor transplantation, equipped with the latest 3D Xi Da Vinci system. Adopting this system not only decreases the risk factor, but also helps achieve minimal scarring and early recovery.

How can people maintain good liver health?

People must bring a change in their lifestyles, which includes avoiding junk, abstaining from alcohol, and exercising daily. In case a person does develop Liver disease, timely intervention in the form of early diagnosis and treatment can completely reverse the process because the liver has immense regenerative power. In cases of an irreversibly damaged liver, Liver transplant can be a life saver. Liver is the only organ in the human body that can regenerate to its full original size, even after removing 70% of the liver. It is for this simple reason why so many transplants and liver surgeries are feasible.

The Inner Me

Three Words that Describe me: Hardworking, kind, Intuitive

My Idol: My Mentor, Prof Abhinav Humar, Chief of Transplantation at UPMC

My favourite quote: "If everyone is moving forward together, then success takes care of itself" – Henry Ford

What success means to me: to me, success is constituted by a well-rounded life in all aspects that brings positivity to myself and those around me

Values of life that are most important to me: teamwork, integrity, and spirituality